Braving the Weather

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at https://archiveofourown.org/works/79904081.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
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Gen

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Catra & Glimmer (She-Ra)

Characters:
Glimmer (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra)

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Emotional Hurt/Comfort, Queen Glimmer (She-Ra), Glimmer Needs a Hug (She-Ra), Catra Needs a Hug (She-Ra), they're doing their best, Anxiety Attacks, Bonding, Past Trauma, Horde Prime's Ship (She-Ra), Cause that doesn't just go away, Bow and Adora are only there briefly, Though Bow is mentioned a fair bit cause this is from Glimmer's pespective lol, i love them, Best Friend Squad (She-Ra), Post-Season/Series 05, Post-War, And resulting PTSD, Though all fairly minor/implied

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by sakarrie

Summary

The war is over, and though no one expected adjustment to be easy, they also didn't anticipate just how much Etheria has been changed. As a creeping cold starts to settle over Brightmoon, Glimmer can't help the tension growing within her. She's okay now. Everyone is. They won. But for some reason, a mere gust of wind is still enough to send her running.

Turns out, she's not the only one.

Originally written for the Icebreaker Zine hosted by the SPOP Creative Flex discord server. Posted as part of the Thank You, She-Ra event.

Notes

Hi guys!

This is my first She-ra fic, so hopefully the characters feel decent! Ngl, I'm very much a Glimbow gal, so I'm pretty surprised this ended up so focused on Glimmer and Catra, but it just felt right. These two have so much shared trauma and similar guilt complexes, so I loved diving into how that manifests itself post-canon. This was originally written for the free She-ra Icebreaker fanzine available here . There's a lot of super talented people involved, so check it out! The theme of the zine was Winter. and Prime's ship always felt like it would run cold to me for some reason, so I took the theme and ran haha. I also am posting this today as part of the Thank You, She-Ra event . It's a wonderful low-pressure event meant as an opportunity to say thank you to the show leading up to it

leaving Netflix today. I'm so devastated that the show is getting shoved to the side like this with all its beautiful messages and representation (along with content quality!!), but I know my love for the show isn't going anywhere and I hope all of you plan to stick around too. <3

Hopefully the starting explanation is understandable! The science of it is pretty half-hearted, but essentially I was going with the idea that Etheria's weather was mostly unchanging since it existed in an empty dimension for so long and had nothing but its moons influencing things. After it's been pulled into the wider universe with suns and stuff that it would likely naturally start revolving around, I figured that could lead to some climate change and potentially seasons the way we have them. Anyway, none of that is actually important, but hopefully it makes sense enough in loose concept that it's not too distracting haha.

Anyway, sorry for the long A/N and hope you enjoy the story!

See the end of the work for more notes

No one notices how much coming into the wider universe has impacted Etheria until after the war.

At first, the changes are fun—how the leaf colors change, the fuzzy hats people start to wear, the occasional breaks from Brightmoon's perpetually sunny weather. But then it keeps going, and Glimmer finds herself growing more and more on edge.

The castle adjusts fairly quickly. Frosta sends extra blankets, and soon Castaspella has a completely operational warmth-containment spell surrounding the castle and nearby towns. In fact, Glimmer is usually able to forget about the cold altogether.

So much so that when someone from Thaymor comes, concerned about the Whispering Woods, Glimmer assures them without a second thought that she would personally check up on the status of the Woods. She doesn't think about the cold until much later.

The day is misleadingly bright, and Glimmer regrets wearing her regular attire as soon as she, Bow, and Adora step out of the castle. She's gone to much colder places in the outfit, though, so she ignores the goosebumps covering her skin as they enter the forest to meet Perfuma. Glimmer tries to pay attention to the plant princess's analysis of the trees, but nothing seems to ease the tension building in her.

Then suddenly a large gust bursts through the trees. Glimmer jerks as if someone shocked her, the crisp air seeming to pass straight through her skin.

She can't be out here. She can't do this.

In a moment, Glimmer is back in the castle and curled up in her bed. The air is warm again, but her whole body trembles. One blanket, then two, three.

Eventually, her shivering loses intensity and her thoughts slowly thaw.

A tentative knock at the door brings Glimmer back, and she realizes how ridiculous she acted. Did she really just completely flake on her friends? She can't even remember the excuse she threw out, but from the way Bow reached for her as she teleported away... it was clear he didn't buy it.

And if he’s already back at the castle, she must have been moping in here for a lot longer than she realized. And what, because she’s cold?

She groans, pulling her top blanket up to cover her head as if that can hide her from the embarrassment. Bow is going to come in any moment and see her, but she can at least pretend she has a chance of him leaving for another couple of seconds.

To her unfortunate lack of surprise, she hears the door creak open a moment later. She feels her face flush as she buries her face deeper into the blankets.

“Please leave, Bow. I’m fine. Just tell the others that I forgot some queenly duty or something.”

There’s a small pause.

“Oh, we wouldn't have bought that for a moment, Sparkles.”

Glimmer drops the blanket from her face, surprised at the distinctly un-Bowlike voice that responded. “Catra?” She feels her face burn harder. Now that she thinks about it, this is even more embarrassing than Bow seeing her like this. She turns over so her back is facing Catra, hoping the other girl will take the not-so-subtle hint and leave.

She doesn't.

The silence eats at Glimmer and with each passing moment, she feels increasingly overdramatic. What is she even doing? Finally, she can't take the quiet any longer. She turns back around in defeat, hands covering her still-burning face as she curls up

further. “Ugh, sorry for running off. It was dumb. I don't even know why I did it.”

“Probably for the same reason I did.”

Glimmer lowers her hands to stare at Catra questioningly. The girl is leaning against the wall with her arms crossed over her chest. Her gaze is fixed to the ground with a nonchalant expression. Her tail betrays her discomfort, though, as it flicks through the air behind her.

“You...?”

Catra shrugs. “Yeah, I’d been looking for an excuse to leave basically the whole trip. You suddenly darting was a pretty good one. Especially since Melog could teleport me back way faster than anyone else could run, though arrow-boy certainly seemed to be considering it.”

Glimmer flops back against the bed with a groan. “I must have really freaked him out, didn’t I?”

“Yeah, your sudden exit was pretty dramatic,” Catra replies. Glimmer just groans again in response. Catra’s tail starts to swish a bit faster. “Look, I’m not really great at the whole comforting thing, but I guess I just thought it might help to know that you’re not alone. And... and that I’m here if you want to talk to someone who gets it.”

Glimmer hesitates for a moment, but then slowly pushes herself up again. She pulls her legs to her chest, resting her chin on her knees. “I didn’t expect the cold to affect me so much. I used to love visiting the colder areas of Etheria, but now it just...”

“Prime’s ship?”

“Yeah. I never really understood why they had to keep it so cold.” Glimmer sighs. “Probably just more of his mind games.”

“Probably,” Catra agrees. She walks over and awkwardly sits down next to Glimmer. “I mean, Wrong Hordak seems to do totally fine in warm temperatures.”

Glimmer shifts uncomfortably. “Do you... Does it ever feel like—”

“Yeah,” Catra says, tension entering her voice. “I don’t think the others even realize how hard seeing Prime’s face everywhere is. It’s been... a process... to get used to.”

“I hate this,” Glimmer declares. “It’s so stupid that everything is just another sign of how much he got under my skin. Everyone’s safe now. He’s gone, yet I still find myself terrified by a friend’s face. And now what? A gust of wind? How am I supposed to lead Brightmoon through its recovery when half the time I’m still stuck in the past?”

They sit in silence for a few seconds before Catra replies, words thoughtful. “In some ways, maybe that makes you a better candidate. No one escaped this war without damage. Everyone is grieving, processing, healing... I’d be more concerned if the person in charge didn’t get that. Wouldn’t you?”

Glimmer huffs, her thoughts immediately going back to how her mom seemed to navigate the aftermath of a war with complete poise. Though, even as the thought comes, another memory arises as well. Her mom yelling in panic, pain arching through Glimmer’s body as she shoved her away. And then those piercing words, I’m the one who got your father killed!

It washes over her like a bucket of water. The guilt in her mom’s voice, how the admission burst out of her like it had been simmering for years. Maybe her mom hadn’t always been as collected as Glimmer had thought.

She forces herself to think back on everything she’d felt in that moment. The fear, the pain, the guilt when she thought she got Entrapta killed... But surpassing all of it was the comfort of

knowing her mom understood the weight she felt. The relief of knowing it wasn't just her.

"I guess I would," Glimmer finally replies. "I just— My mom always seemed to have everything together. Even when she was struggling, she was always so composed. Sometimes it's hard to feel like I'm living up to what she would do if she were still here."

Catra's sudden flinch takes Glimmer aback for a moment, then guilt rushes through her as Catra quickly looks away. That was such a stupid thing to say. Glimmer's legs fall to be crossed as she leans forward, eager to take back the damage she'd just done. She opens her mouth to speak, but—

But what is she going to say? That her mom's death isn't Catra's fault? That it's okay that she'll never see her mom again? They would both know it was a lie.

At the same time, Glimmer knows how much Catra has changed. She's seen with her own eyes how far Catra has gone to try to atone for how many people she'd hurt. And Glimmer knows what it's like to have made irredeemable mistakes and be desperately scrambling to make up for it.

Glimmer knows Catra's actions now can never bring her mom back, but at the same time... "I don't hold my mom's death against you."

Catra looks up in surprise, and there's a brief moment where their eyes meet for the first time tonight before her gaze darts away again. Her voice has the barest hint of a tremor when she speaks again. "I was the one who opened the portal."

"And I was the one who activated the heart," Glimmer replies heavily. "There's no changing our past. We'll be carrying the weight of those errors our whole lives." She turns her attention back to Catra and waits until the girl hesitantly looks back up with wet eyes. "But I want you to know that I don't think of you as the person who got my mom killed. I think of you as a friend."

Catra's face scrunches, and for a moment she looks mad—until Glimmer realizes there are tears starting to slip down her cheeks. Catra wipes at her eyes furiously. "Geez, Sparkles. I didn't realize coming to check on you meant agreeing to a waterworks show." Catra chuckles, and Glimmer laughs, hearing the thickness in her own voice too.

"But... thank you," Catra continues. "You're right. I'm never going to let go of what I've done. I've hurt far too many for that to be fair. But I'm going to continue to do whatever I can to make up for it. However long it takes."

"Me too," Glimmer says firmly. A draft brushes over her exposed shoulders, sending a shiver up her spine. She tugs the blanket higher to cover more of her shoulders as she feels her muscles grow tense again. "I don't know how you hide it all so easily."

"Lot's of practice," Catra says a bit bitterly before softening. "But I'm working on it. On trusting that my friends want to help." She bumps Glimmer's shoulder playfully. "Bow's a pretty good listener, you know."

Glimmer laughs. "Yeah, he is." She cocks a playful eyebrow Catra's way. "You know, you're not too bad yourself."

Catra snorts. "Yeah, right. I came in to check on you and ended up crying myself."

"It made me feel a little less stupid about hiding, though," Glimmer admits with a shrug.

"Huh," Catra says, lightness entering her tone. "Me crying makes Queen Glimmer smile. Noted. What was that about seeing me as a friend?"

Glimmer shoves her. "Oh, shut up." Her grin falls. "We probably should go back out to finish the meeting with Perfuma."

Catra shrugs. "Eh, Adora and Bow have handled that kind of stuff before."

A strange guilt twirls in Glimmer's stomach at the truth in the statement. "Yeah, but they shouldn't have to. I'm the Queen. I can't hide away just 'cause I don't like the cold."

A strange look crosses Catra's face and a corner of her mouth lifts. "How did it go... Just because we can't change our pasts doesn't mean we deserve to continue to suffer for it? Something like that."

"Is that something Bow told you?"

"Perfuma, actually."

Glimmer huffs. "That would have been my next guess. But, yeah. I guess there's no reason we have to go back to meet them. They might already be back even."

"I'll send Melog to check," Catra says, pushing herself up off the bed.

Glimmer takes a deep breath as she prepares to take off the blanket. She knows the air isn't that cold, but she can't shake—

Something soft suddenly smacks her in the face, knocking her out of her thoughts with a small oof.

"And put on a jacket, dummy."

Glimmer laughs, looking up to reply, but Catra has already disappeared out the door. Smiling softly to herself, she puts on the jacket and climbs out of bed to go meet her friends.

End Notes

Thanks for reading! If you have a the time and energy, comments absolutely make my day! <3

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!